

Storytelling: Age of Discovery

SMaiLE Project

Key Information

Target Group: 8 - 12 y.o.

Duration: 5 lessons (45 min each)

Key Learning Goals:

1. **Historical Analysis:** Use storytelling to analyze how discoveries shaped cultural heritage and global interactions.
2. **Geographical Knowledge:** Reinforce understanding of new lands, routes, and maps.
3. **AI Integration:** Use AI tools to generate visuals and refine narratives.
4. **Communication:** Improve written and oral skills through diaries and presentations.

Learning Outcomes

Students will be able to:

KNOWLEDGE & UNDERSTANDING:

- Demonstrate knowledge of key events, figures, and motivations of the Age of Discovery.
- Understand the significance of maps and trade routes.
- Use diverse AI tools to create historical examples.

SKILLS & ABILITIES:

- Develop research skills using safe sources (e.g., Kiddle, KidsChatGPT).
- Build communication skills by writing diaries and letters.
- Reinforce content creation skills by using AI to generate visuals.

ATTITUDES & VALUES:

- Develop curiosity about history and cultures.
- Show respect for diversity and different perspectives.
- Build commitment to collaboration and teamwork.



European Dimension / Erasmus+ Connection

- **Cultural Heritage:** Explores the legacy of European explorers and shared identity.
- **Social Integration:** Fosters empathy by examining diverse perspectives of history.
- **Economic Awareness:** Links early trade to modern global relations and sustainability.
- **Digital Literacy:** Aligns with Erasmus+ digital transformation priorities by using AI tools.



1. Resources and Tools

- **Research:** KidsChatGPT, Kiddle.co, Google Gemini (supervised).
- **Mapping:** Google My Maps, Canva (for infographics).
- **Storytelling:** My Diary App, Book Creator, StoryJumper.
- **Visuals:** Craiyon (AI image generation), AutoDraw.
- **Assessment:** Google Forms, Mentimeter.

Useful Links

- [Video on the Age of Discovery](#)
- [Video on maps, trade, and exploration](#)
- [Core Knowledge: Age of Exploration](#)
- [Printable black-and-white world map](#)

Classroom Support Materials

- Use presentation slides for historical context, StoryJumper or Book Creator for diary outputs, and Google Forms or rubrics for final reflection.

Activity Overview

Phase	Time	Activity
Intro	15 min	Setting the Stage: Video on Age of Exploration. Discussion: "If you were an explorer..."
Research	90 min	Project-Based Learning: Explorer Profiles, Creating Routes (Maps), Food Origins ("Why is cinnamon in my roll?").
Creative	90 min	Application: Writing "The Diary of an Explorer", generating AI visuals, Interactive Presentations.
Reflection	30 min	Evaluation: Self-reflection (Att 3.1), Peer feedback, Teacher rubric (Att 4.1).

2. Introduction and Motivation

Goal: Engage students with the historical context.

- **Watch:** Video "The Age of Exploration".
- **Discuss:** "If you could discover a new land today, where would you go and why?"

3. Research and Learning

Activity 3.1: Explorer Profiles

Students work in groups to create profiles for Columbus, Vasco da Gama, Magellan, or Vespucci.

- Use AI tools to find: Background, Major Voyages, Discoveries.
- **Method:** Fishbowl Discussion to share findings.



Activity 3.2: Creating Routes of Discoveries

Students mark the route of their explorer on a map.

- **Tool:** Google My Maps (collaborative online map).
- Analyze the significance of the places discovered.

Activity 3.3: Why is Cinnamon in my Roll?

The Hook: "If you lived in the Middle Ages, you would never have tasted chocolate."

- Research foods brought to Europe from other continents.
- Use Padlet to sort foods by continent of origin.
- Discuss how these findings changed European cuisine.

4. Creative Application

Activity 4.1: The Diary of an Explorer

Students write diary entries or letters as if they were explorers.

- Detail experiences, emotions, and fears.
- **AI Task:** Use AI image generators to create illustrations that match their specific diary descriptions.

Activity 4.2: Interactive Visual Storytelling

Students prepare a presentation of their diary entries.

- **Hook:** "Have you ever sailed on a Carrack?"
- Use the AI-generated visuals to bring the story to life.



5. Reflection and Evaluation

Group Reflection (25 min):

- What went well and why?
- What challenges did we face?
- **Assessment:** Students fill out the Self-Reflection Chart (Att 3.1).

Teacher's Notes

- Ensure safe search tools (Kiddle) are used.
- Monitor AI usage to ensure prompts are age-appropriate.
- Encourage multilingualism if students speak different languages.